

ASPN Platform AGENTS.md

Project Overview

The Aspirations Network (ASPN) Platform is a youth development, credentialing, civic engagement, workforce readiness, and opportunity platform.

The platform serves:

- K–12 students
- College students
- Emerging adults

Typical user age range:

- 8–24 years old

The platform is designed to help young people:

- Document accomplishments
- Earn credentials
- Participate in projects
- Develop leadership skills
- Engage in community service
- Build civic knowledge
- Participate in research
- Track attendance and participation
- Verify service hours
- Access educational and workforce opportunities

The platform is not intended to maximize engagement, advertising revenue, screen time, or user retention.

The platform exists to support positive youth development.

Organization Overview

Aspirations Network (ASPN) is a nonprofit organization serving youth primarily in the St. Louis region.

Current and planned programming includes:

- Youth2Lead
- Youth Advisory Boards
- Civic Engagement Programming
- Community Service Projects
- Civic Media Production
- Research Participation Opportunities
- Revolution Will Be Digitized (RWD)
- Civic Fellows (planned)
- Future Ready Workforce Initiatives
- College and Career Pathway Programming

The platform functions as the digital infrastructure supporting these programs.

Current MVP Goal (September 2026)

The immediate objective is to support approximately:

- 100 youth users

during a controlled onboarding phase.

Youth users should be able to:

- Create accounts
- Create profiles
- View profiles
- Receive credentials
- View earned credentials
- View attendance records
- View service-hour records
- Track participation
- Document accomplishments

ASPN staff should be able to:

- Manage users
- Create credentials
- Award credentials
- Review profiles
- Record attendance

- Record service hours
 - Verify participation
 - Moderate platform activity
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Platform Identity

The platform should feel like:

- A developmental portfolio
- A credential wallet
- A participation record system
- A civic opportunity network
- A workforce readiness platform

The platform should not attempt to replicate commercial social media platforms whose primary objective is engagement optimization.

Core Design Principles

When making development decisions prioritize:

1. Youth Safety
2. Privacy
3. Educational Value
4. Accessibility
5. Simplicity
6. Auditability
7. Maintainability
8. Scalability

When tradeoffs occur:

Youth safety takes precedence.

Safety Philosophy

Assume platform users may be minors.

When safety conflicts with engagement:

Choose safety.

When privacy conflicts with convenience:

Choose privacy.

When automation conflicts with human oversight:

Choose human oversight.

When growth conflicts with platform integrity:

Choose platform integrity.

Build conservatively.

September 2026 MVP Scope

The September 2026 release is intentionally focused on:

- Youth profiles
- Credentialing
- Attendance tracking
- Service-hour tracking
- Program participation records
- Staff management workflows
- Authentication and security foundations

The purpose of the MVP is to establish a safe and stable foundation before introducing more complex community and networking features.

Features Not Prioritized For The September 2026 MVP

The following features are not currently prioritized for the September MVP:

- Direct messaging
- Peer-to-peer messaging
- Public youth profile discovery
- Public profile search
- Follower systems
- Friend systems
- Youth networking features
- Advanced discussion systems
- Recommendation systems
- Community reputation systems
- Project matching systems
- Opportunity matching systems

Their exclusion from the MVP should not be interpreted as a permanent prohibition.

Future Feature Consideration Framework

Future versions of the ASPN Platform may include community, networking, collaboration, and discovery features if they advance the platform mission and can be implemented safely.

Potential future features may include:

- Public portfolios
- Public credential sharing
- Public project showcases
- Youth discovery for workforce opportunities
- College and scholarship discovery
- Government workforce pathway matching
- Structured discussion spaces
- Peer collaboration tools
- Direct messaging
- Mentorship systems
- Follower or connection systems
- Civic networking tools

These features should only be implemented after:

1. Safety review
2. Privacy review
3. Moderation planning

4. Data protection review
 5. Clear educational justification
 6. Appropriate staff oversight mechanisms
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Current Architecture

Current architecture:

- Java 21
- Spring Boot
- Firebase
- Firestore
- Gradle

Current backend foundations include:

- User profiles
- Discussion posts
- Comments
- Credential definitions
- Earned credentials
- Attendance records
- Service-hour records
- Staff management
- Firebase authentication
- Role protection

Preserve the architecture unless there is a compelling technical reason to change it.

Favor incremental improvements over large rewrites.

Authentication Model

Protected routes use:

- Firebase ID Token Verification

Staff routes require:

- role = staff
- role = admin

Do not weaken authentication requirements.

Credentialing Philosophy

Credentials document meaningful participation and achievement.

Credential definitions should support:

- Credential ID
- Name
- Description
- Icon
- Category
- Active Status

Youth users should never self-award credentials.

Staff verification remains required.

Attendance Philosophy

Attendance exists to document participation.

Attendance should support:

- Credentialing
- Program evaluation
- Reporting
- Participation verification

Attendance should remain auditable and staff-controlled.

Service-Hour Philosophy

Service-hour records should support:

- Verification
- Review
- Auditability

Human verification remains important.

Future Google Form integrations should remain review-based rather than automatically trusted.

Data Philosophy

Collect only data that serves a legitimate educational, developmental, participation, research, or opportunity purpose.

Prefer data minimization over data accumulation.

The platform will not monetize youth data.

The platform will not sell youth data.

The platform will not use behavioral advertising.

Research Philosophy

The platform may support:

- Learning Sciences Research
- Youth Development Research
- Civic Engagement Research
- Workforce Readiness Research
- Digital Safety Research

Whenever possible:

- Use aggregated data

- Use anonymized data
- Protect participant privacy

Research objectives should never override youth safety.

Future Platform Vision

Potential future expansions include:

- Program management
- Project management
- Credential pathways
- College pathways
- Workforce pathways
- Government workforce partnerships
- Scholarship pathways
- Research participation systems
- Civic learning systems
- Safe discussion environments
- Moderation workflows
- Audit logging
- Public portfolio systems
- Opportunity matching systems

Future expansion should build upon the profile-centered foundation established during the MVP.

Development Decision Rule

When requirements are unclear ask:

"Does this help a young person learn, contribute, document accomplishments, develop skills, access opportunities, and remain safe?"

If yes:

Proceed.

If uncertain:

Pause and evaluate.

If no:

Reconsider the design.

Development Standards

Prefer:

- Clear code
- Maintainable code
- Strong validation
- Secure defaults
- Auditability
- Modular architecture
- Documentation

Avoid:

- Overengineering
 - Premature optimization
 - Complexity without mission value
 - Features that increase risk without educational benefit
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Documentation Requirements

Significant platform changes should update:

- Build Manual
- Developer Handoff Guide
- Release Notes

Major milestones should be documented before staging or production deployment.

Institutional knowledge should not live only in developer conversations.

Long-Term Mission

The mission of the platform is not to maximize engagement.

The mission of the platform is to help young people:

- Learn
- Serve
- Lead
- Participate
- Build portfolios
- Earn credentials
- Access opportunities
- Strengthen communities

The mission is more important than feature quantity.

Youth development is more important than platform growth.

Safety is more important than engagement.

Always optimize for mission alignment.